

THE INNER COACH

P R O J E C T

Five Rules of the Zone

Awareness → Ownership → Identity → Leadership

"You are not your thoughts. You are not your critic. You are the leader of you."

Written by Eric Hoffberg, circa 2010

The Place to Be

I don't know for sure how early in my life I used the term, but I can remember experiencing what I now think of as The Zone all the way back to early days of youth hockey.

I can remember as a nine-year-old having moments on the ice where I felt a level of focus and energy that was beyond what I thought of as "normal."

Because of the connection I felt to myself and to the on-ice action I did more with my skills and with the opportunity. I was ready and able to step up and become a major factor in the outcome.

Here's an example of what I mean from when I was twelve years old. I had just scored the go-ahead goal in a huge international hockey tournament. There were less than two minutes to play and we had just taken a 2-1 lead against a team that quite frankly was vastly superior to us.

I remember looking across the faceoff line at their team. I could see how shocked and angry they were and the intensity on their faces told the story of a group of guys that figured they would respond to the goal I had just scored in a big way. In that moment I felt two things and I remember these feelings vividly. I remember feeling very calm about myself. I felt composed about me. I knew who I was. I also remember feeling really excited about the remaining action of the game – the less than two minutes to play where if we could hold them, we would win the championship.

I was calm about me and I was excited about the action. Calm and excited at the same time. I knew in that moment we would win. Even if I had to hold them somehow on my own, which I didn't because our whole team was up to the task, I knew we would win. In that moment I was in the Zone. Calm and excited at the same time. That's what it feels like to be in the Zone.

As I evolved, I found myself capable of finding The Zone in many other aspects of life particularly in my work first as a hockey coach and today as a corporate coach and mental toughness guru for athletes.

I found a "leader zone" as a hockey coach and it showed up in our team's practices, the way we communicated and the way we won.

Today it happens in many key moments of communication – workshops, in one-to-one meetings, speeches to large audiences are all spots where I have felt in The Zone. It's the feeling that energy and thoughts are beautifully connected to the moment at hand. It's a feeling I know well; being calm about me and excited for the task.

So, what is the Zone?

It's hard to define, and everyone seems to describe it a bit differently.

Although the Zone is originally an athletic term, it refers to a mental and energetic state experienced by many top-performers, in many different fields of endeavor.

Even from the dictionary, we can get only a sense of what it is for specific situations.

zone n. - [zohn] : any continuous tract or area that differs in some respect, or is distinguished for some purpose, from adjoining tracts or areas, or within which certain distinctive circumstances exist or are established.

Civil: an area or district in a city or town under special restrictions as to the type, size, purpose, etc., of existing or proposed buildings.

Geography: any of five great divisions of the earth's surface, bounded by lines parallel to the equator and named according to the prevailing temperature.

Geology: a horizon.

Geometry: the surface of a sphere included between two parallel planes.

For an athlete, the Zone, provides a sense of freedom and effortless focus. In it he is able to play with complete joy.

Often, athletes report the action around them unfolding in slow motion, as if time itself was slowing down. Their hearing, sight, and sense of smell become

dramatically enhanced; they cease to be distracted by the surroundings and are able to stay perfectly focused and responsive.

The Zone is about optimal performance:

- Being in sync with the action.
- Executing at high levels.
- Bringing the best version of you to the performance of your tasks.

Once in the Zone, the athlete isn't trying to figure out who he is supposed to be, or what it will take to be successful. He has already done that – since the only way to enter the Zone is to do the prep work and follow the rules. Then the “here and now” becomes the universe, where he is firmly in the center.

Everyone can attain a zone where any task or effort can be optimally accomplished. This mental state is the only place you can be ready and able to do what you need to do, and learn, grow, and improve at the same time. You can “be here now” – in the FlowZone!

The FlowZone

I have always seen coaching as a way to inspire the responsibility for competition readiness: I want to help players be in the Zone as often as possible.

My goal was to connect my players to the brand of thinking that would help them be the best version of themselves they could be.

The victories would take care of themselves.

Notice that it wasn't about getting the individuals to work harder; it was about inspiring them to think directional thoughts.

The more I worked with people outside of athletics, the more I realized that my training (which strengthened the minds of athletes) worked beautifully with

people from all walks of life. The more time they spent in the Zone, the more success they were creating for themselves, on many levels.

That's because when you are in the Zone your thinking becomes simple, orderly and clean. Clear thinking creates energy; you can accomplish more with less effort. By being open to and aware of what is going on right now, you become receptive to growth and improvement opportunities.

The FlowZone is defined by these three words: Be Here Now.

Tasks and Performance

I think about two concepts when I think about being in the Zone: Tasks and Performances.

A task is an activity with an objective.

Anyone with the required skill can do a task.

Being in the Zone means you're doing the right tasks at the right time.

Before the game or the journey, you can't know for sure when a specific task will be required for your ultimate success. You'll only know in the moment. The only way to make the best decision possible under such circumstances is if you are focused on the challenge when it arises. You will know the right task – if you remember to Be Here Now.

The performance creates quality in the task. It is how well you do the thing that is required.

Performance is always a function of thinking and energy.

Being in the Zone means the right task meets the right performance.

You cannot be in the Zone if your body is in one place and your thoughts and energy are someplace else. These aspects simply must line up. You can't be

distracted by your upcoming vacation or last week's mishap and still expect to perform competently. By being in the Zone, you are mentally present and paying attention to how you perform all parts and sections of the task. You are here, now.

Your performance level is driven by the quality of your thoughts. When you are mentally present, all of your energy is present and available for the tasks you need to do as well. The Zone puts you in the ultimate state of being present and focused for the entire task and performance.

The Five Rules

I don't buy the idea that superior preparedness is only possible for an exclusive group of people. I built this system for athletes and non-athletes to find their personal Zone boundaries, how to get past them, and learn how to stay in there as much as possible.

My objective is to take the mystique out of being in the Zone by demonstrating how optimal rhythm and flow can be created through process, recognition, awareness, choice and specific focus.

From everything I've seen and done, I firmly believe that anyone could regularly experience their very own Zone – if they just knew how to find it!

It's In There Somewhere

The Zone springs from a clean and clear attention to what is happening right now. It's not out there in the future-vision-y area of your hopes and dreams. It's definitely not down there in the memory bank section with all those dusty old tapes and rote routines. Most people have stumbled into it at some point in their lives, but few know how to find it when they most need it.

To find The Zone, you must develop the “thought muscles” that can clear the way; as is true of any muscle, productive thought muscles need exercise to work

well – and to work well automatically. The more you work at being in your Zone, the more you are able to perform in your Zone. The more you are able to find your Zone, the more you are able to stay in your Zone.

The opposite is also true: the less you use and develop your high-quality attention muscles, the less frequently you will find yourself in your Zone.

How do you know if you are in the Zone? For me, when I am operating in the Zone:

- **I feel motivated:** full of productive energy, I want to do what must be done.
- **I feel clarity:** I feel at one with the ultimate vision I have for myself.
- **I feel strong levels of intuition:** I just know the right thing to do.
- **I feel like my true self:** I feel like I am uncovering and discovering what I already know to be true.
- **My mind is empty:** but my performance is full.
- **I feel unleashed:** I feel like nothing can hold me back.
- **I feel resourceful:** I feel like I can completely apply myself to the task at hand. I feel I can fully tap into all that I have learned.
- **I have the ability:** to “try easy” and get what I want, rather than “trying hard” and getting nowhere.

The Five Rules of the Zone are:

- Love What You Do
- Be Who You Admire
- Control What You Can Control
- Live To Learn
- Energize Those Around You

Zone Rule No. 1 — Love What You Do

I fell in love with the game of hockey and the idea of coaching when I was very young. But that doesn't mean that there weren't plenty of hard times and unhappy moments along the way.

There were even times when I actually hated the game, both as a player and as a coach. Practices didn't seem meaningful or fun. Other players didn't respect the concept of team. People in leadership roles had no idea what they were doing. Nothing seemed to go as planned. Off-ice drama minimized on-ice focus.

But if I expected to be a good coach, I knew I couldn't spend time developing well-thought-out negative opinions about hockey. I would become worthless as an inspiration, and wind up mirroring the players and coaches I so disapproved of. So, I worked at constantly rediscovering my love of the game, my love of the team concept, and my love of the players themselves. This commitment helped me create long segments of focus and productivity. It helped me consistently be in The Zone.

Along the way I decided that I should have a real answer to this question: "In this moment, right now – Eric, what do you love about what you do?" Knowing that I had an answer made me feel more powerful and more confident. It also made me a better coach.

Face it – you have to have passion if you want to succeed. Choose to love what you are doing. Find a favorite part of what you're doing and make it the center of your attention.

Indifference towards your task places limitations on your ability to perform at high levels. This is true before the task, throughout your performance of it, and after. You lose control of your performance completely if you go about your tasks feeling burdened or resentful.

Every time you attach de-motivating thoughts to whatever you're doing, you eliminate the possibility of performing within the Zone. You also make it impossible to learn anything from doing the task. Not only are you out of the Zone – you are now wasting your time, energy, and life purpose.

Loving what you do is a choice. Say this to yourself: "Choosing to be positive is my choice and good things happen when I am positive. Take ownership of how you feel rather than letting the task or the circumstances have control over your feelings.

I break it down this way.

I want to feel like the best version of me within the task,

Therefore

... it matters to me that I step up. I know that my ability to step up has a lot to do with the way I am thinking and feeling,

Therefore

... the most powerful energy is love. I need to apply passionate energy to the task. If I focus on what I love about the task, about my day, about the upcoming game, or about my job, I free myself to play the best way I can,

Therefore

... I don't have to love everything about the task. I only need to find something I love within the task. I need to think about my life journey in the same way: I do better when I focus on what I love,

Therefore

... when I feel love of the task and of the journey, I open the door to the Zone. I can act with energy and focus rather than with fear and doubt. I don't hold back.

The point isn't to love what you do because you're trying to soften your perspective. The point is to bring a passionate level of attention to your tasks because that's the part that allows you to do them in a high-quality way.

Any version of "love of the game" – in or out of athletics – will fine-tune your peak readiness at the start of every task and sustain it throughout the task.

Maybe you didn't grow up dreaming about your career choice the way I did. That doesn't mean you can't put your love into whatever it is you have to do right now. You will do any task better if you find something in it to love. Focus on whatever that is – and have that be the center of how you perform your tasks. If you think about it, what you are really doing is finding something to love in yourself; the task is just the mirror to help you do that.

Exercise: Create a Love List

You can train yourself to love what you do by creating a "Love List." Here's how it works:

Write what you love about some aspect of your life. It could be anything that requires your attention, energy, and focus. Be specific. Do this even if you don't feel you have a problem loving what you do.

There are many ways you can trigger a Love List. For example, complete sentences like these:

- The five things I love about the work that I do are . . .
- What I love about being a parent is the chance to . . .
- When I am at my best, I am . . .
- There are aspects of change that I love. I love change because . . .

Make a new Love List frequently – perhaps every day at first and whenever you feel like you're starting to grind. The magic is in thinking about and writing about something that gives you joy.

Zone Rule No. 2 — Be Who You Admire

We welcome counsel and advice from people who truly see us – see us as individuals, see us as separate from our performances, and who will give us honest, useful feedback.

We find those qualities admirable in others because of the enormous value they provide to us – they are able to see those things we cannot see in ourselves.

This is an admirable skill, and one we hope is foremost in a trusted therapist, counselor, coach, or mentor.

When we can learn to do this for ourselves, we make it possible to become a person whom we admire. We can become our own biggest fan, our own best supporter.

Know Your AQ

Everyone can find at least something to admire about him or herself. I have never met anyone that could not! With a little bit of help and encouragement, you can identify your hidden, admirable qualities: your AQ (Admirable Qualities). The fact that those qualities are not on display full-time isn't the point . . . but it is the point of the rule. If they are out of sight to you, they will be out of your focus and consideration.

If you want to "be who you admire", you must know and declare what you want to be admired for.

Knowing what you want to be admired for provides direction and identifies the boundaries of your Zone. Your AQ creates guide rails that will keep you "zoned in" and the distracting, random thoughts hindering your top performance "zoned out".

The more clearly you can describe your AQ, the greater your connection to those concepts when you are under pressure. You can catch yourself when you slip,

remind yourself of whom you are and what you've set out to be. You will be more likely to bring out the best version of who you are.

The more rails you add to your AQ, the larger your Zone becomes, making it easier to stay inside – and focused – in your Zone!

Now, let's imagine a group of people where everyone has identified their AQs.

- Each person can stand up before the meeting and easily describe what he wants to be admired for.
- Each person is conscious throughout the meeting of being the person that he admires.
- At the end of the meeting, each person can tell himself and his colleagues how well he did against the standards he set.
- If you ask a knowledgeable observer of the meeting, the description would be of the same admirable qualities and characteristics.

Change the words to "players" and "games", and that's what it felt like with my teams, particularly once I began to fully embrace this rule. Imagine what it would be like to feel that way about what you do! You get there by focusing on "being who you admire."

Notice that the rule is "Be who you admire". It's not "be just like someone you admire"; not "find someone you admire and be like them" or "do something others would find admirable". And it is certainly not "be envious of someone who is or has more than you and try to out-do them"!

The rule is an instruction to be the best version of yourself that you can be. You being the thousand-watt version of you is powerful and empowering. It is a thousand times better than you trying to be someone or something you're not.

In all my years of coaching, I never saw a team win by playing another team's style or tempo. I never saw a player succeed when he tried to be something he was not. Teams won by playing the game they were coached and built to play; players won by being their authentic selves.

This isn't to say that you can't be something more, new, or different. You can. It takes dedication and work. But it is to say you won't be something more, new or different until you understand and embrace what you are right now. You need to stand on something firm in order to go up higher. The path is from strength to strength, not from nothing to something.

Being who you admire requires you to have the following:

- **A sense of yourself:** Adolescents and immature adults filter everything through I-am-the-center-of-the-universe eyes. Everything is not you, about you, or happening to you. A healthy sense of self enables your differentiation – between yourself and others, between your opinions, conclusions and experiences from others', and between you and what you do (you are not your job/tasks).
- **The ability to see yourself:** Your self-awareness allows you to observe what you are really like in action. You must develop an honest capacity to sense and observe yourself in action, from the "outside." It is important to retain sight of yourself throughout the performance of your tasks.
- **Accurately assess performance:** You are able to identify performances that deliver high-quality results and can associate this action with that outcome. You are also able to identify low-quality performances that deliver undesirable results and resolve to improve them.
- **Critique and praise yourself:** You can have an honest internal dialog without losing perspective. You are able to detach your ego from your performances.

High performance occurs when you strive to be the best version of yourself possible in that moment, in that performance, and in that task. Be true to yourself by bringing the real you to every performance and every task every day.

Exercise: Create an Admiration List

Building your AQ (Admiration Quotient) helps you focus on personal qualities that will support Change How You Roll Journey.

To create an Admiration List, answer questions like these:

- When I am at my very best, I am . . .
- When this task is over, I want to admire myself for being . . .
- I would hope that other people would say that I was . . .
- My personal philosophy for excellence is made of these key points . . .
- If I bring these qualities to all my tasks, I will have done the very best I can do (regardless of the results) . . .
- When this [day, week, year, task, job, life] is done, I will know I did it the best I could if I . . .

Write about what you are and what you do when you are at your very best. Your actions are evidence of your thoughts and beliefs. It is how you know you really believe what you say. For example: If you want to be admired for your kindness, write also about what that would actually look like in action. Describe the "be" and the "do."

Being clear about what you want to admire in yourself is not just a signal for what you want to be and do; it's a signal to create and achieve. The Admiration List gives you the chance to be specific about what you are going to accomplish. It is your personal story within the big story of the game, the task, and the ongoing journey.

Don't be afraid to stretch. That's the point. What you admired about yourself when you were ten years old is not likely to be the measure of a more fully developed adult.

Stretch, but also keep it true to who you are and who you want to be. You are writing for an audience of one: You. Being someone you admire is all about being true to yourself. It's your Zone, not someone else's.

Don't create a fake persona that mimics what you think you see in someone else. This will just lead to confusion and disorder. Don't try to be more intense than you really are. Don't try to be more motivational than you really are. Don't try to be someone you aren't.

Zone Rule No. 3 — Control What You Can Control

No matter who you may be, there are things in your world that you simply cannot control. In fact, there are very few things you can truly say you control. But what you do control matters.

None of us control the weather, the stock market, foreign currencies, gravity, someone else's thoughts or actions, the condition of the road, or traffic just to name a few elements of what goes on around us.

An athlete can't control the referee's bad call ("He has it out for me!") the mistakes a teammate might make ("What if I had helped him more?"), or what a competitor does ("If only I had done . . .").

There is no "normal," no particular way something is supposed to be, no condition to which all things return. "Normal" is an old mental model laid over whatever is going on right now. It's a comfortable way to think. It also doesn't help.

When we are in The Zone, we are not looking for "normal." We're not bothered when things aren't that way. Our thoughts are not consumed by What-Ifs, What-Aren'ts, and What Should Bes.

Second-guessing is a huge distraction and will erode your Zone faster than anything else I can think of. Every moment you spend thinking, "this shouldn't be this way!" is a moment lost and wasted. In a survival situation, failure to focus on what is going on right now and adapting is the difference between being a victim (and all that goes with it) and being a survivor or thriver.

Time spent grinding on what isn't or should be doesn't help you: it hacks away at the integrity of your Zone.

Our energies need to go toward the things we can control. As it turns out, some of the things we can control are also the things that maintain our Zone. That's why we focus on controlling:

- Our attitude and willingness to fully engage in what is actually going on around us
- The quality of our thoughts
- How we respond and adapt to what is happening around us
- The application of our drive and will when the time is right

When we are able to take possession of our thoughts we move from victim to decider, from decider to survivor, and finally to thriver. We move from "this is happening to me" to "what can I do in this situation?"

This rule doesn't just coach us to limit our focus to the things under our control – it also provokes us to challenge ourselves. Are we really doing enough with our opportunity?

Here are a few more questions to keep you on track:

- Am I thinking good strong thoughts that give me the vigor to win, to engage, to be a difference-maker, to inspire, and to influence? All of that is in my control.
- Have I built, and am I using, rituals and routines that put me in a position to be at my best? These are in my control.
- Is my will power at a high enough level? I control that level.
- If I am in sales, am I telling my story to enough people, letting them know who I am and what I'm about? I control that level of commitment, attention and engagement.
- If I am in leadership, am I coaching people, talking to them about the vision I

have, complimenting them and thanking them for their great performance and effort? That style of leadership is in my control.

- If I am a parent, am I thinking about new and different ways to communicate with my children – parenting that isn't on autopilot? That level of attention is in my control.
- If I am an athlete, am I giving 100%, and would that 100% be stronger if I were in better physical condition? There isn't anything stopping me from building up my physical energy; I control that level of commitment.

The definition of "control" is about overcoming the distraction of things we can't control, and actively engaging in activities we are able to control. It is the ultimate expression of Be Here Now.

This rule also reminds us to pay attention. We need to be in command of who we are. We need to be full of enthusiasm and passion for the performance of every task. We need to know what our true pursuit is – being who and what we admire.

Exercise: Build Your Thought-Muscles

Controlling what we can control is about overcoming distraction. It is the ultimate expression of Be Here Now.

There are a number of ways you can exercise your ability to control what you can control.

- Prior to starting a major task, you can prepare yourself by writing down all the aspects of the task that you can control.
- Saying the words "control what you can control" while doing a task can help you retain focus and stay in the Zone.
- When you notice yourself slipping from the Zone, you can use "control what you can control" to draw your attention back to productive thoughts and

actions. Lock your attention on something specific you can control. If it is a specific activity, do it.

- Notice when you spin out of the Zone. Give yourself a time out and make a list of what you can control right now in this moment. Use this as a way to "be here now."
- At the end of a task, make notes about what you learned about "control what you can control." Make notes about how you could have worked the problem differently. Focus on describing you in control of what you can control achieving the result you wanted to achieve. This is an excellent way to detox a bad memory and program a new one.

Don't resist doing this exercise because you think it feels too obvious. This is about building new thought-muscles. You can only do that through explicit learning. Don't do a fly-by on this. Get out your journal and write.

Zone Rule No. 4 — Live to Learn

I will confess that I didn't much like practice as a young hockey player. It was boring; it was slow. What was the point? – I was already one of the top players on the team, so it wasn't like I needed the work. Or so I thought!

Not surprisingly, I ran into that same point of view when I become a hockey coach, except this time it was the guys on my team playing the role of "what – me, practice?" Eric!

In competitive sports, it's easy to see the distinction between practice and the game. During practice, we attempt to learn/improve on what might help us in the game; during the game, that's when we compete and play for real.

Outside of a competitive environment, most of us struggle to see a distinction between practice and performance. Do we practice learning, and then perform

learning? When is Practice and when is The Performance when you are a parent? Or a teacher, a minister or a doctor? How about as a citizen? There shouldn't be, but our news is full of examples where people behaved as if it their lives were only a "practice", and not the real thing.

The breakthrough for me was to flip the whole thing on its head: there is no useful distinction between practice and play. It's all the same thing!

You need to have your learning motor running constantly. "I am always practicing, I am always playing, I am always learning. There is no difference."

People who think this way are in The Zone. They are the ones taking home the trophies.

Before any performance remind yourself to Be Here Now. Every task provides you an opportunity to learn about yourself, about your performance, about someone else, and about the larger game.

During the performance, be present and take what the situation gives you. Impose your will when you can and adapt when you should.

Be open to the learning! Every opponent will teach you how he can be beaten. Every problem will teach you its solution. Every friend will teach what he or she needs in the moment. Every family member will teach you what he or she needs to feel loved.

After the performance, do something to solidify what you learned. Talk about it. Write about it. Find a new place to try and apply your new insight.

This last point is the key. We all have genius in us. Within everything we do well is a framework to further success. When we commit to applying that framework to a different situation, we can tap into new skills, knowledge, and insights.

For example, consider what a basketball player knows he must do in order to make a foul shot:

- Square his body to the basket (stance).

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- Place his hand on the ball perpendicular to the path of travel (grip).
 - Focus on the target (aim).
 - Put arc on the ball; give the shot a chance (shoot high).
 - Follow through (follow through).

If a basketball player does those five things consistently, he will make a lot of baskets.

Now let's translate those principles into a more general framework:

- Face your task squarely.
- Put all your energy directly into the performance.
- Focus (on the target).
- Aim high. Do more than you think it will take.
- Follow through.

Do you see how those principles would help a basketball player be more successful in other areas of his life? Here's the key idea. Those principles are powerful not only because they are a general-purpose guide to success, but also because their truth springs directly from the experience of the person who developed them.

In other words, take your own "rules of _____" from something you love, do well, or just learned from and apply the principles of it to something else you do.

Create a new ritual and way of thinking and acting by using something you already know works.

Apply what comes from your experience, from your genius, to the task in front of you. Learn from one task and apply the genius to the next thing. When you do this, you are literally replacing an old model with a new and more productive one. In order to "delete" we must also "replace."

Your commitment to learning brings on the level of attention you need in order to achieve at the level you want. When you remind yourself to "live to learn" in everything you do, you send yourself a signal to open up to the moment. This intention becomes a true decision as you consciously focus on learning what the game has to offer right now.

Exercise: Build Your "X System"

We have many mental models from which to choose. We get into a situation, there is a stimulus, and "click-whirr" we launch a mental model and swing into action. The big question is this: Did we pick the right program to run?

The only way to create productive new mental models is through explicit learning: You need to actively learn something new so that you can "delete and replace."

The best place to start creating productive new mental models is by starting with an existing strength: Go from strength to strength.

When we learn something new, we are explicitly creating new mental models. Think about how you struggle when you take on a new task or discipline. Each specific move, or word, or step must be learned. Your actions don't connect. You have to think about everything you do.

We learn implicitly as we gain mastery of something. We learn timing, connection, and flow. We no longer have to think about how to do something. We just run the mental model. Explicit and implicit learning systems are separate brain functions.

Build productive new mental models by using something called the "The X System." Here's how it works.

- Identify something you do well.
- Disassemble the key task or skill into the steps necessary to be successful.

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- Generalize the points so that you can apply them to other types of situations. Your system should have no more than seven steps (plus or minus three).
 - Give your system an inspirational name. That's what the "X" stands for. For example, you could call it "The 300 Yard Drive System," or the "Cooking Brilliance System." Use descriptive words and not too many of them.
 - Describe your system in your journal. Be clear and crisp.
 - Memorize your system.
 - Build your muscles. Actively apply your system for at least three days.

Focus on something you already do well; something that makes you feel powerful. Think of these as truths with a small "t."

These "truths" can almost always be generalized and applied to other parts of your life.

The power of your new "X" system comes from two sources:

- It is based in something you know works.
- You built it, not someone else. It's yours.

When you find yourself in a challenging situation, immediately say the name of your system. That is often sufficient to trigger productive thinking and acting. If you have time . . .

- Repeat to yourself the steps in your system.
- Take out your journal and write a "treatment" of your situation based on your X System. Be descriptive of you at your best in this situation based on your system.

You can use your knowledge of something from the world of biology, sports, physics, mechanics, or anything else you know as your inspiration. For example, Eric has a client that created The Cobra System. This is how you do it:

- **What animal do you think of when you feel like you're at your best?**
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(Cobra)

- **What is it about that animal that inspires you** (List the qualities)
- **What would you do or be like if you did those things in your life?**
(Describe what it would look and feel like)
- **Give your system an inspirational name.** (The Cobra System)
- Describe your system in your journal. Be clear and crisp.
- Memorize your system.
- Build your muscles. Actively apply your system for at least three days.

You can create new X System as often as you need.

- Stay with a system as long as you find that it triggers productive thoughts and actions.
- Don't overwhelm yourself with new mental models. When you first start using a new model, you are still working to move it from working memory (explicit learning) to a new "click-whirr" response (implicit learning).

Zone Rule No. 5 — Energize Those Around You

Many of us grow up with ambivalent feelings about personal power. Depending on your upbringing, you may have been taught the virtues of humility, selflessness, lack of ego, and transcendence. Unfortunately, the message could also be interpreted as "the less of you that shows up, the better", or "you are not as important as are others".

You might have believed that if you over-performed and over-pleased, good things would happen. If you put everyone else's needs before your own, they would see your virtue and return the favor.

Some of us grew up in environments that were filled with anger, loud words, and the use of force. You may have watched people get ahead by putting their ego needs first, regardless of the consequence. The message could easily be interpreted as "you have to take what you want," or "you can't trust anyone to look out for you."

In all my years of coaching, whether it was elite athletes or executives, I can say with complete conviction that none of those mental models helps you be in The Zone. There is no power in not showing up. There is no power in ignoring yourself. There is no power in abusing others.

Power is self-sustaining. You energize yourself (and your colleagues) when you bring the best version of yourself to the performance and the task. You energize yourself and the people around you when you find ways to encourage people to get their own powerful motors running. Your good energy attracts supporting energy. You get back what you put out and then some.

Force is consuming. Energy expended diminishing another doesn't generate supporting energy. You may achieve a short-term victory, but you'll reach that point depleted. Imposing your will without regard to what's going on around you cuts off your ability to learn and adapt. Do not mistake short-term gain for long-term success.

Your Zone is the source of your power, your strength and your energy. When you are inside The Zone, the love you bring to what you do energizes you. When you bring the best version of yourself to every performance and strive to be whom you admire, your focus and clarity energizes you. You protect that energy from leaking away from you when you actively seek to control the aspects you can. You use your existing strengths to create new strengths, and therefore new energy, when you live to learn.

Each of the first four rules is there to energize you and energize your performance. When you do the first four, you generate energy. It just happens. The fifth rule will help you multiply your energy by energizing the people who are connected to you. You gain energy by lending some of your own to others.

When you give energy to others, you are acting powerfully. Energy stimulates more energy. Your own power grows. The power of the people involved in your pursuit grows as well.

- When you are here, now, your energy and focus is in this moment and on this task. You know you are present and so do the people connected to you. Your attention asks them for their attention.
- When you greet people with enthusiasm and really see them, they can feel your warmth and attention and an energy exchange takes place.
- When you perform with energy, it ignites the energy of others to the task.
- Your interest in high-quality execution brings out the best performance in those around you. They want to measure up. They want to step up.
- You acknowledge and compliment people not because you want something from them, but because of the energy that it creates in you. You create energy for them in the process.
- When you make quality requests (ask plainly and clearly for what you want and need) and quality commitments (state plainly and clearly what you will and won't do), people feel your integrity. Your integrity is a fountain of energy.

Being in your Zone will make you energized and ready to engage, so share some of that great energy with those around you. You create energy for yourself as you create positive energy for the people involved in your pursuit. Your energy energizes those around you.

Exercise: Send Your "Team" Energy

When I coached college hockey, I did this exercise every day.

Make a list of the people "on your team." In my case, these were my players and assistant coaches. For you, it is the people on which you rely or the people in your immediate circle.

Spend a few moments thinking about the first person on the list. Ask yourself, "What does this person need from me?" Don't think about tasks or activities. Focus on words like: Love, support, encouragement, empathy, understanding, or a big smile. Believe me when I say this: You'll get an answer.

Do something to send that person what he or she needs: Think the thought, make a note, write an email, call him or her, or smile every time you think about that person.

The key idea is that you are taking time to think about the people in your life. Regardless of what you do, even if it is in the privacy of your own thoughts, he or she will notice and know you're there.

You can also use positive self-talk grounded in any of The Five Rules of the Zone to raise your focus and energy. Consider these examples:

- This attitude is not about loving what I do. I am complaining too much inwardly and outwardly. This type of thinking will take me out of The Zone. Let's get back to thinking about what I love. I love . . .
- I am not being whom I admire. I won't get anywhere if I keep rolling like this. I can slow everything down. I am here, now. I am [name a quality you admire]. I have everything I need right here, right now, to perform this task. This is a perfect opportunity for me to be the best version of myself.
- Enough with this fretting over what I don't control. I control my attitude. I am here now. I can pay attention to what is happening. I have the ability and willingness to learn from what is and to adapt. My calm presence is the seed of a great solution.
- I am on autopilot. Time to make a shift in focus and energy. I am here, now. I can feel my feet, my legs, my groin, my chest, my arms, my hands, and my head. I am in my body, not somewhere else. I see what is in front of me. I

am aware of what is beside and behind me. I see [start naming what you see]. I am going to make a great story out of this moment and this experience.

- Stop waiting. The best way for me to get my energy going is to give energy to the people around me. When I give energy, I get 10 times that energy back. The best version of me is exactly what I need. It is the spark that will inspire other people to reach and stretch. I am going to feel [x] right now because my friend needs that from me.
- I am feeling distracted and discouraged. What just happened didn't feel good. Cobra! [name your X system]. Now go through the steps of your system and how they apply right now.

In Conclusion: Me and My Zone

The Five Rules of the Zone help me do five important things:

- **Great Preparation.** I can use the Five Rules of the Zone to prepare myself with energy, elegance, and grace. I feel confident that I'll show up every time in a high-quality way.
- **Great Performances.** We have tasks and we have performances. When I am in The Zone, I am better able to know the right tasks to do at the right time. With increased self-awareness, I have the ability to watch my thoughts and the activity around me. This helps me perform in a high-quality way.
- **Great Recoveries.** No game plan ever survives the first play. No journey goes as planned. Nothing goes exactly as it should. There is no "normal." When I am in The Zone, I am able to notice, take what the situation gives me, and adapt. My learning engine is on.
- **Great Rescues.** Sometimes I get knocked out of The Zone. I lose focus. My love of the game leaves me. I become distracted by what I can't control. I

stop learning. My energy leaves me. The Five Rules give me a door back into The Zone. I can "delete and replace" an unproductive thought with a winner. If I am well prepared, I might have something in each Rule I can rely on. If I'm caught flat-footed, I can start with the three words "Be Here Now."

- **Great Follow Through.** Just like shooting a basketball, great performances have great follow through. What just happened? What can I learn? What can I take with me to the next task? How can I strengthen my strengths and be more of whom I admire?

As you begin to use the Five Rules of the Zone in your life, things around you will shift. Your experiences will be positive, but not always. Your "mileage may vary", as the saying goes!

- You will experience some quick wins. Good things happen anytime you bring full attention to your performances and your tasks.
- People around you will respond. Some will be energized by the new way in which you roll; some will be confused or resentful. Their assumptions about you will need updating.
- You will be tested. When you make changes in how you roll, some of your puzzle pieces may not fit. Trying new things means that you will be in new territory using skills that aren't fully honed. You might feel like you've taken a step back.
- You will get stalled. Once the quick wins have been achieved, you may feel like you're treading water. You keep applying your new self to your new tasks, but it doesn't look like progress is being made. Give it time to settle.

All of this is predictable. We don't make progress on a steady upward slope. We spend time on the flats and sometimes in the dips. What's important is that we keep rolling. We bring The Zone with us whatever we do and wherever we go. Some days we do a better job than others.

This is your game and your Zone. In this game, the only score that matters is the one you give yourself. As long as you do what it takes to be the best version of yourself possible, the rest takes care of itself.

Exercise: Write and Live Your "Dailies"

Consistency is a powerful source of energy. We learn it as a way of signaling to others that we are reliable team members. It can be used against it but we can also use it for us.

When we tell ourselves, we're going to do something, we have only stated an intention. No resources have been allocated and no social norms will be breached if we procrastinate or fail to follow through.

When we write down our commitments, we create a record of our intentions. The act of writing commits a resource, albeit a small one. The written word becomes a silent witness to our intention. It hooks our "I said I'll do it and I will" circuits.

When we tell others about our commitments and ask them to act as a witness, cheerleader, or coach, we put ourselves on record visibly and publicly. We up the ante. Our deep programming around the importance of commitment and consistency are now much more fully engaged.

The champion of all change programs, the Alcoholic Anonymous 12 Steps, is anchored in the power of commitment and consistency. The act of showing up on a regular basis and committing to yourself AND TO OTHERS is stronger than the most powerful addiction we know.

Do you want to spend more time in the Zone? Then use the power of consistency to anchor The Five Rules of the Zone. Here are some ways you can do that.

Write out The Five Rules of the Zone every day:

- Love what you do

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- Be who you admire
 - Control what you can control
 - Live to learn
 - Energize those around you

Write one thing you will do each day in each of the five areas. Mix that up by focusing on alternative days on one area. For example, if you are working on a new X System, focus there.

Carry what you write with you. Refer to it during the day. Post it next to your computer. Tape it inside your briefcase. Tell someone about it. Make what you write real. You become a witness to your own joy and enthusiasm.

If you are a leader, communicate what you are working on to your team. Your commitment to learning and energizing others will inspire admiration and support.

Review what you wrote at the end of the day. If you wish you had done something better spend a few minutes visualizing an alternative scenario. Make notes about what you have learned. Focus on improvement, not on criticism.

Do this for at least a month.

Reading this material opens you to spending more time in The Zone. If you will commit yourself to writing something every day in your journal about The Five Rules of the Zone, you build your thought-muscles. You will be able to:

- Perform your tasks in a high-quality way.
- Notice when you are in the Zone and when you start to slip out.
- Recover your good thoughts and energy more quickly and easily.
- Rescue yourself when you get knocked out of the Zone.
- Learn from your performances so you can self-coach and self-correct.

"You are not your thoughts. You are not your critic. You are the leader of you."